



SKOAR!

Siddharth "staticsid" Parwatay
feedback@skoar.com

Ever had one of those crazy potty thoughts where you wondered which mythological god would kick the most ass? Is Zeus' thunderbolt more powerful than Thor's hammer? Or better yet what would happen if we put some of the all powerful entities from Indian mythology into the mix? SMITE the latest MOBA game from Hi-Rez studios (makers for Tribes) gives you the chance to do just that. For those of you new to the genre, MOBAs are Multiplayer Online Battle Arena games. In fact you may have even played one of these games and not known the genre. Think of the immensely popular DOTA (Defence Of The Ancients) and you'll know what we're talking about.

There are of course other games such as Heroes Of Newerth and League of Legends that follow this format and in that SMITE is no different. And what is this format? Quite simple - you spawn on one side of the map with your four comrades. There are three lanes or approach routes that lead up to the enemy base. Along these routes there are defensive structures called towers. Your objective is to break through these defences and kill a minotaur in the enemy camp. Throughout the gameplay sets of computer controlled creeps or minions will spawn and make their way along each of the lanes towards the enemy camp. Minions are expendable creatures and your character - champion, hero or god as it's called in SMITE - will invariably use them to draw fire. By killing creeps or other gods you gain

XP with which you can level up and upgrade skills. Speaking of skills each god has unique skill suited to the kind of character. As for the gods, there are mages, tanks, melee fighters, range fighters etc. All of this is boilerplate stuff. So what's the big deal about this game? SMITE deviates from the top-down view and goes into the action with a third person view. Also the action is more immersive as character movement controlled by keyboard instead of mouse control which has traditionally been the norm. The gameplay is super fun. There's a huge variety of gods that you can unlock using favour points that you earn in each match. Each god has his/her specialties. Some are good early game, some become lethal after levelling up considerably, some have nuke skills (with long cooldown periods), some are fast and good for chasing down and picking off weak enemies and for strategising with teammates you have predefined voice commands (besides chat of course). Oh and a bonus thrill - there are Indian gods and mythological beings to choose from! There's Agni, Kali, Vamana and Bakasura for now and the possibility of more Indian gods joining the ranks as the game approaches release. Now the game did spark minor murmurs of controversy abroad concerning the idea of having playable gods but the concept isn't new here or particularly offensive. Remember the indigenously developed PS 2 game Hanuman?

The game is currently in beta and we find very little wrong with it per se. There are balance issues (which MOBA doesn't really?) but the most irritating thing is the wait time before matches. You have to wait on average five to eight

minutes while the server finds players and puts you in a match. Hopefully, these will be ironed out by the time the game officially launches. *

Verdict

Getting into the action with WASD controls and the innovative third person camera puts a new refreshing spin on the old DOTAEsque format. We liked it for the immersive action, aesthetics, variety in gods, and it's noob-friendliness i.e. the auto buy items and auto upgrade skills option.

MOAR!

- » **Developer:** Hi-Rez Studios
- » **Platforms:** PC only
- » **Price:** Free to play
- » **Release Date:** Q1 2013

Minimum requirements

- » **Processor:** Core 2 Duo 2.4 GHz or Althon X2 2.7 GHz
- » **RAM:** 2GB (XP), 3GB (Vista, Win7)
- » **Graphic card:** ATI Radeon 3870 + or Nvidia GeForce 8800 GT +
- » **Space:** 10 GB free

